

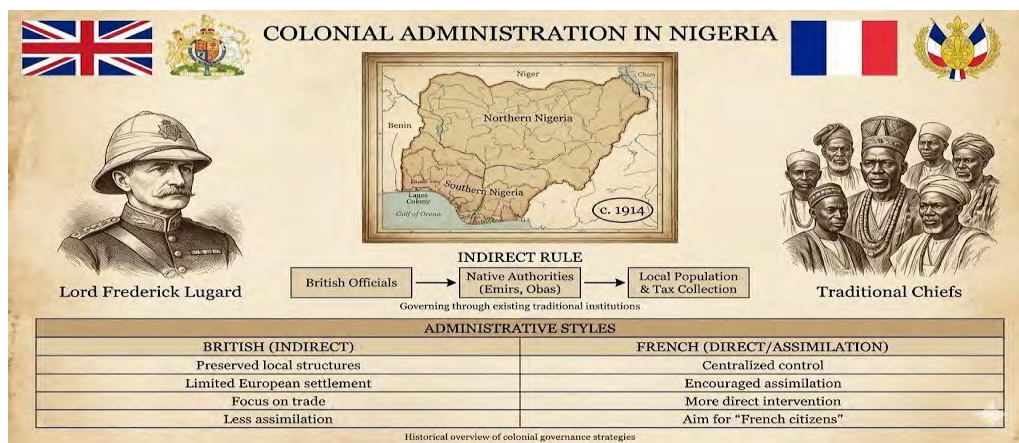
SS 2 GOVERNMENT WEEKS 1-6

Week: One

Topic: Colonial Administration in Nigeria: British, French, Indirect Rule

COLONIAL ADMINISTRATION IN NIGERIA

Colonial administration refers to the system of governance established by European powers to control and manage their colonies. In Nigeria, colonial administration began formally with the annexation of Lagos in 1861 and evolved through various stages until the country gained independence in 1960.



Colonial rule was primarily motivated by economic exploitation, political dominance, and the spread of Western civilization. Two major European colonial powers operated in West Africa: Britain and France, each implementing distinct administrative systems in their respective colonies.

1. The system was characterized by decentralization and collaboration with existing traditional institutions and rulers. Rather than dismantling indigenous power structures, the British strategically co-opted them, thereby enabling local rulers to maintain authority over their people while simultaneously serving colonial interests. This approach was cost-effective for the British and made administration more manageable across the diverse ethnic and cultural groups in Nigeria. Indirect Rule System

The Indirect Rule system was the cornerstone of British colonial administration in Nigeria.

Under this arrangement, the British governed the people by appointing and using traditional rulers as intermediaries. These rulers—such as emirs in the North, obas in the West, and chiefs in other regions—retained their traditional roles but now functioned within a colonial framework. They were expected to implement colonial policies, collect taxes, maintain law and order, and settle minor disputes. However, their powers were subject to the supervision and approval of British colonial officers, particularly the District Commissioners. The British believed this system would reduce resistance from the local population since governance was carried out by familiar figures within traditional power structures.

2. Preservation of Traditional Institutions

In order to ensure the success of the Indirect Rule system, the British deliberately preserved and upheld traditional institutions and hierarchies. They recognized the legitimacy of established rulers such as the emirs, obas, and chiefs, integrating their authority into the colonial administration. This strategy was particularly effective in Northern Nigeria, where Islamic and emirate systems were already centralized and well-structured. In the Western region, the Yoruba traditional systems with their councils of chiefs and oba structures also lent themselves to indirect governance. However, in the Eastern region, the British faced challenges due to the absence of centralised authority among the Igbo people, who traditionally practised a more decentralised and egalitarian political system. As a result, the British introduced the system of

“warrant chiefs,” appointing individuals as rulers who often lacked legitimate traditional support, thereby causing long-term sociopolitical tension in the region.

3. Use of Native Authorities

A critical component of the British administrative system in Nigeria was the establishment and use of Native Authorities. These bodies consisted of traditional rulers and their councils, who were now empowered to perform specific administrative and judicial roles under colonial oversight. The Native Authorities operated native courts, which handled local disputes using customary laws. They also managed native treasuries where taxes and other revenues were collected and accounted for. Additionally, native police forces were created to enforce colonial laws and maintain internal security within local areas. While these authorities retained a

traditional appearance, they were ultimately instruments of British colonial control. Their success depended heavily on the strength and acceptance of local leadership, and in many cases, their legitimacy eroded due to excessive taxation and abuses of power.

4. Decentralised Administration

The British implemented a decentralised system of administration in Nigeria to enable effective control of the vast and diverse colony. Nigeria was divided into provinces, each administered by a British Resident. These provinces were further divided into divisions, overseen by District Officers, and again into districts managed by Assistant District Officers or local rulers under British supervision. This multilayered structure allowed for the efficient implementation of colonial policies while accommodating regional differences. Decentralisation also meant that each region could be administered according to its unique socio-political traditions, albeit within the overarching framework of British colonial authority. This administrative approach allowed the British to manage vast areas with relatively few officials, although it also led to regional disparities and uneven development across the colony.

5. Dual Legal System

Another distinctive feature of the British colonial administration in Nigeria was the existence of a dual legal system. This system allowed customary laws to operate alongside British statutory laws. Indigenous laws, based on local customs and traditions, continued to govern personal matters such as marriage, inheritance, and land tenure. However, these customary laws were only recognised if they did not conflict with British legal principles. In instances where a customary practice was deemed “repugnant to natural justice, equity, and good conscience,” it was struck down by colonial courts. This legal duality provided a sense of continuity and cultural respect for the indigenous population but also caused confusion and conflict, particularly where overlapping jurisdictions led to contradictory rulings. Over time, the dual legal system influenced the development of Nigeria’s post-independence legal framework, which still accommodates both customary and statutory law.

Structure of British Colonial Administration in Nigeria

The British colonial administration in Nigeria was a hierarchical system that reflected the

centralised authority of the British Crown while incorporating elements of local governance through Indirect Rule. This structure enabled the British to maintain control over a vast and culturally diverse colony with limited administrative personnel. The system was built around key levels of authority, each with specific roles and responsibilities, ensuring that the policies of the colonial government were effectively implemented from the top to the grassroots.

- *Governor*

At the apex of the colonial administrative structure was the *Governor*, who served as the highest-ranking British official in Nigeria and the direct representative of the British Crown. The Governor held executive, legislative, and judicial powers and was responsible for the overall governance of the colony. He was appointed by the British monarch on the advice of the Secretary of State for the Colonies in London. The Governor issued ordinances (laws), implemented colonial policies, supervised all administrative officials, and maintained communication between the colonial government in Nigeria and the British authorities in London. Following the amalgamation of the Northern and Southern Protectorates in 1914 by

Lord Frederick Lugard, Nigeria came under the leadership of a single Governor-General, further centralising colonial authority.

- *Lieutenant-Governors*

Directly under the Governor were the *Lieutenant-Governors*, who were responsible for the major administrative regions of the colony—particularly the Northern and Southern Protectorates before and after amalgamation. These officials acted as regional heads and served as the link between the central government and the provincial administrations. They ensured that policies from the central government were adapted and executed within their respective regions. Lieutenant-Governors had considerable autonomy in decision-making, particularly due to the vast distances and communication challenges that existed at the time. They played a crucial role in maintaining regional stability and enforcing colonial laws across the protectorates.

- *Residents and District Officers*

Below the Lieutenant-Governors were the *Residents* and *District Officers*, who were key

functionaries in the implementation of colonial policy at the provincial and district levels, respectively. Each *Resident* was assigned to a province and acted as the principal British official in that area. The province was further divided into *divisions* or *districts*, each overseen by a *District Officer*. These officials were responsible for maintaining law and order, collecting taxes, administering justice, and supervising the activities of Native Authorities. They frequently moved around their districts to monitor compliance and address grievances. District Officers were often the most visible representatives of the British colonial government to the rural population, and their actions had a direct impact on the daily lives of the people.

- *Native Authorities*

At the grassroots level were the *Native Authorities*, which were composed of indigenous rulers such as emirs, obas, chiefs, and council members. These traditional leaders governed local communities under the framework of Indirect Rule, serving as the lowest rung in the administrative hierarchy. Although they retained their traditional titles and authority, their actions were subject to the supervision of District Officers and Residents. Native Authorities were responsible for tax collection, local policing, dispute resolution through native courts, and the execution of colonial directives within their territories. Their effectiveness largely depended on their legitimacy among the people and the level of support they received from the colonial government. While this system worked relatively well in the North, where traditional structures were strong, it faced challenges in regions where such authority was fragmented or non-existent

The French Colonial Administration in West Africa

The French approach to colonial administration in West Africa differed markedly from that of the British. While the British favoured decentralisation and indirect rule through traditional institutions, the French adopted a more rigid and uniform system characterised by centralisation and a strong emphasis on assimilation.

The French colonial model aimed to integrate African colonies—such as Senegal, Côte d’Ivoire, Dahomey (now Benin Republic), and others—into the French state politically, culturally, and legally. Their goal was not just to govern, but to transform Africans into “Frenchmen in black skin.” This approach had profound effects on indigenous societies, administrative structures,

and post-independence development in Francophone Africa.

1. Centralised System

A defining feature of French colonial administration was its strict centralisation. Power was concentrated in Paris, the capital of France, where key decisions regarding the colonies were made. The French Ministry of Colonies in Paris exercised direct control over all colonial matters, including governance, economic policy, education, and legal affairs. The colonial territories were regarded as integral parts of France, rather than as separate dependencies. As such, the colonies had little to no autonomy and were administered in a highly bureaucratic manner, with colonial governors and administrators expected to implement directives exactly as prescribed by the central government. This centralised system allowed France to maintain tight control over its colonies, but it also stifled local innovation and failed to account for the cultural diversity of the African population.

2. Policy of Assimilation

At the heart of French colonial ideology was the *policy of assimilation*. This policy sought to make Africans culturally, politically, and legally identical to French citizens in mainland France. The French believed that through education and exposure to French civilisation, Africans could be transformed into loyal subjects who thought, spoke, and behaved like French people. As a result, the French language was imposed as the official language, French laws were introduced, and French cultural values were promoted in schools, churches, and public institutions. Indigenous traditions, languages, and religions were discouraged or outright suppressed. The policy of assimilation reflected France's belief in the universality of French civilisation and its superiority over African ways of life. However, in practice, assimilation was largely symbolic and applied only to a small elite who were educated in the French system.

3. Direct Rule

Unlike the British system of Indirect Rule, the French employed *Direct Rule*, which involved the systematic dismantling or marginalisation of traditional political institutions. Local rulers, where they existed, were stripped of meaningful authority and were either replaced by French officials or turned into figureheads with no real power. French colonial officers held executive, legislative,

and judicial powers at all levels of administration. These officials were trained in France and were expected to enforce French laws without adaptation to local customs. In areas where traditional institutions were tolerated, they operated under strict French control and had little influence. This direct administration fostered a more uniform colonial structure but often led to resentment and resistance among the colonised populations, who saw their indigenous identity and sovereignty being eroded.

4. Uniform Legal System

Another key feature of French colonial rule was the imposition of a uniform legal system based on French civil law. French law was applied consistently across all colonies, with little regard for local customs or traditional legal practices. This approach was part of the broader assimilation policy, which sought to create a homogenous legal and cultural identity across France and its colonies. The legal system governed issues such as taxation, property rights, criminal law, and civil liberties. Courts were established in the colonies that operated exclusively under French legal codes, and French-trained magistrates presided over cases. Although this system created administrative uniformity, it often alienated the local population and failed to address culturally sensitive legal matters effectively.

5. Citizenship Rights

A unique aspect of French colonial administration was the conditional granting of citizenship rights to certain Africans. The most notable example was in Senegal's *Four Communes*—Saint-Louis, Gorée, Rufisque, and Dakar—where African inhabitants who embraced French culture and education could qualify for French citizenship. These individuals, known as *évolués* (meaning "evolved" or "civilised"), were entitled to rights such as voting, access to French courts, and eligibility for public office. However, the requirements for citizenship were stringent and often exclusionary. Africans had to renounce their customary laws and practices, adopt European dress and manners, and demonstrate loyalty to France. As a result, only a tiny fraction of the population qualified. Nevertheless, the citizenship policy symbolised the French commitment to assimilation and sharply contrasted with the British policy, which rarely extended such rights to colonial subjects.

Comparison between British and French Systems

Features	British (Indirect Rule)	French (Assimilation)
System of Administration	Decentralised	Centralised
Role of Traditional Rulers	Prominent	Marginalised
Cultural Policy	Tolerant of customs	Imposed French culture
Legal System	Dual (Customary & British)	Uniform French law
Goal	Control through local rulers	Assimilation into French society

The Policy of Indirect Rule in Nigeria

The policy of **Indirect Rule** was the cornerstone of British colonial administration in Nigeria. It was introduced by *Lord Frederick Lugard*, first in Northern Nigeria where existing centralised political structures such as the emirate system made it easier to implement. The system was later extended to other regions, including the Western and Eastern parts of Nigeria, although with varying degrees of success. Indirect Rule involved governing the people through their own traditional rulers, who were retained as the recognised authorities in their communities but now acted in the service of the British colonial government. These rulers were expected to implement colonial policies, collect taxes, settle disputes, and maintain law and order, all under the supervision of British colonial officers.

The system was designed to reduce the cost and manpower needed for colonial administration while minimising resistance from local populations, since governance was executed by familiar and respected indigenous figures. However, the effectiveness of Indirect Rule differed across regions due to variations in traditional political structures and the level of centralisation. In regions where these structures were strong, such as the North, the policy worked more effectively. In contrast, it encountered resistance and confusion in areas like the East, where traditional authority was more decentralized.

1. Recognition of Traditional Rulers

A fundamental principle of Indirect Rule was the formal recognition of traditional rulers. The British colonial government did not seek to dismantle existing local leadership but rather sought to co-opt these leaders into the colonial administrative framework. Emirs in the North, obas and chiefs in the West, and, eventually, warrant chiefs in the East were retained as the official heads of their communities. These traditional authorities were given administrative responsibilities and were seen as intermediaries between the colonial government and the people. Their status was often elevated by colonial backing, which gave them power to enforce colonial policies. However, this recognition also placed them in a difficult position, as they had to balance loyalty to their people with obedience to foreign rulers.

2. Adaptation of Local Institutions

Under Indirect Rule, the existing institutions of governance—including traditional courts, councils, and customary laws—were not abolished but rather adapted to suit the objectives of the colonial administration. The British aimed to preserve the outward form of local governance while reconfiguring its content to serve colonial interests. In practice, this meant that the emirs and chiefs could continue to operate their traditional councils and legal systems, but with limitations and under the oversight of British District Officers. The adaptation process often led to changes in traditional practices, with some rulers gaining more authority than they traditionally held, and others being stripped of powers they previously enjoyed. The colonial government prioritised efficiency and loyalty over authenticity, which in some cases distorted the traditional balance of power.

3. Minimal European Interference

One of the reasons Indirect Rule was attractive to the British was that it allowed for minimal European interference in local affairs. British officials—such as Residents and District Officers—maintained ultimate control but generally avoided direct involvement in daily administration. Instead, they issued instructions and policy guidelines which were to be executed by traditional rulers and their councils. This hands-off approach meant fewer European administrators were needed, reducing costs for the British Empire. However, this also meant that abuses of power by traditional rulers sometimes went unchecked, as long as colonial interests

were not threatened. In regions where traditional rulers were weak or lacked legitimacy, the lack of direct European oversight led to governance challenges and local discontent.

4. Training of Traditional Rulers

To ensure that traditional rulers could effectively perform their roles as colonial agents, the British undertook the training of local rulers in administrative procedures, taxation, law enforcement, and record keeping. The aim was to transform these rulers into efficient instruments of colonial policy while retaining their traditional authority. The training often included exposure to British governance ideals and a basic understanding of European laws and bureaucratic processes. In some cases, interpreters and clerks were also appointed to assist illiterate rulers. This training reinforced the colonial hierarchy and deepened the rulers' dependence on the British, while simultaneously distancing them from their people. Over time, some traditional rulers came to be seen as mere extensions of colonial power rather than as custodians of indigenous interests.

Success and Limitations of Indirect Rule in Nigeria

The policy of Indirect Rule, introduced by Lord Frederick Lugard, was the preferred administrative system used by the British to govern Nigeria. While it was economically convenient and politically strategic, its effectiveness varied significantly across the different regions of Nigeria due to the diverse political, social, and cultural structures that existed prior to colonisation. The system had clear successes in some areas, particularly the North, but encountered serious limitations in others, especially in the East and parts of the West. These regional disparities highlight the mixed legacy of Indirect Rule and its profound impact on colonial and post-colonial governance in Nigeria.

Success in the North

One of the most celebrated successes of Indirect Rule in Nigeria occurred in Northern Nigeria, where the British found a well-organised and centralised political system already in place. The emirate system, established under Islamic governance following the 19th-century Jihad led by Usman dan Fodio, provided a robust administrative framework with clearly defined hierarchies

and responsibilities. The emirs ruled over expansive territories with subordinate officials such as district heads and village heads, who ensured law and order, collected taxes, and settled disputes. This centralised structure aligned closely with the British administrative objectives, making it easier for colonial officers to implement Indirect Rule with minimal disruption. The British were able to delegate authority to the emirs, who in turn carried out colonial directives while maintaining the appearance of traditional governance. As a result, the North remained relatively stable and orderly under British rule, with fewer instances of open resistance compared to other regions. The success of Indirect Rule in the North made it the model for attempts to replicate the system in other parts of Nigeria.

Challenges in the East

In sharp contrast to the success in the North, Indirect Rule encountered serious challenges in Eastern Nigeria, primarily due to the absence of a centralised traditional authority system. The Igbo people, who predominantly inhabited the region, practised a form of government that was decentralised and communal. Leadership was often exercised through village councils, age grades, and elders, with no single figure wielding absolute authority over a large territory. This structure posed a significant obstacle to British efforts to implement Indirect Rule, which relied on the existence of strong, centralised traditional leaders who could be co-opted into the colonial administration.

To address this issue, the British introduced the “warrant chief” system, appointing individuals as local rulers regardless of their traditional standing or legitimacy. These warrant chiefs were often seen by the people as colonial puppets and lacked the respect and moral authority needed to govern effectively. This imposition led to widespread dissatisfaction and several uprisings, the most notable being the Aba Women’s Riot of 1929, where thousands of women protested against the warrant chief system and colonial taxation. The failure of Indirect Rule in the East stemmed largely from the British misunderstanding or disregard for indigenous political institutions, resulting in instability and resistance.

Resistance in the West

In the Western region of Nigeria, particularly among the Yoruba people, Indirect Rule also met

with resistance, though for different reasons than in the East. The Yoruba had a well-established system of governance with obas (kings) and councils of chiefs, many of whom ruled over powerful city-states and enjoyed significant autonomy. While the British found these structures suitable for their administrative model, their attempt to subordinate traditional rulers to colonial officials was not well received. Many Yoruba rulers resented the erosion of their authority and the interference of colonial officers in their internal affairs.

The colonial government often bypassed traditional advisory councils, imposed unpopular policies through the obas, and manipulated succession processes, thereby weakening the legitimacy of traditional leadership. Some rulers who were seen as uncooperative were deposed or stripped of their powers, further fuelling opposition to British rule. This resistance was not as violent or widespread as in the East, but it reflected a deep-seated resentment towards the way Indirect Rule was applied, especially when it clashed with existing customs and political practices.

Advantages of Indirect Rule

1. Preserved indigenous cultures and institutions.
2. Cost-effective for the colonial government.
3. Reduced resistance by involving local leaders.
4. Encouraged local participation in governance.

Disadvantages of Indirect Rule

1. Empowered corrupt and unpopular rulers.
2. Created social inequality and ethnic division.
3. Failed to prepare Nigerians for modern democratic governance.
4. Inadequate in regions without centralised authority.

Effects of Colonial Administration on Nigeria's Political Development

1. Introduction of Western Education: The colonial administration established missionary and government schools that introduced Western education to Nigerians. This produced a class of educated elites who later spearheaded nationalist movements and demanded self-rule.

2. Creation of Political Institutions: The British introduced political structures such as Legislative Councils and regional assemblies to aid colonial governance. These institutions laid the groundwork for parliamentary democracy and exposed Nigerians to formal political processes.

3. Development of Nationalist Movements: Colonial oppression, racial discrimination, and denial of civil rights led to growing political consciousness. Educated Nigerians began organising protests, petitions, and associations demanding equal treatment and independence.

4. Formation of Political Parties: Nationalist leaders used political parties as platforms to mobilise support and challenge colonial policies. Notable parties like the NCNC, Action Group, and NPC emerged to represent regional and national interests.

5. Ethnic Division and Regionalism: Colonial policies such as Indirect Rule and regional autonomy reinforced ethnic loyalties and divisions. This promoted regionalism and competition among ethnic groups, complicating post-independence national unity.

Assignment:

1. Explain three primary motives behind the introduction of Indirect Rule in Nigeria by Lord Lugard.

Week: Two

Topic: Nationalism in Nigeria:

Nationalism

Nationalism is the strong feeling of love, loyalty, and commitment that citizens show towards their country. In the Nigerian context, nationalism refers to the conscious efforts by Nigerians to challenge colonial domination and fight for self-rule and independence. It was driven by the desire to free Nigeria from British colonial rule and to assert national identity and sovereignty.



Nationalism in Nigeria developed in two distinct phases:

- **Early Nationalism (Traditional Resistance):** Pre-WWII resistance led by traditional rulers (e.g., King Jaja of Opobo, Oba Ovonramwen of Benin) aimed at defending local sovereignty against British economic expansion.
- **Modern Nationalism (Political Liberation):** Post-WWII movement led by educated elites, trade unions, and press media aimed at capturing state power and achieving total independence.

Factors That Accelerated the Rise of Nationalism in Nigeria

A. Internal Factors (Within Nigeria):

- **Growth of Western Education:** Educational institutions like Yaba Higher College and overseas education produced a critical mass of educated African elites who understood Western democratic principles and challenged colonial arguments.
- **Role of the Nationalist Press:** Pioneer newspapers like Herbert Macaulay's 'Lagos Daily News' and Nnamdi Azikiwe's 'West African Pilot' served as aggressive mouthpieces to expose colonial injustices and mobilize public consciousness.

- **Economic Exploitation & Discrimination:** Monopoly of trade by European firms (e.g., UAC), racial wage disparities, poor working conditions, and exclusion of African merchants created widespread economic discontent.
- **Formation of Political Parties & Trade Unions:** The establishment of the NNDP (1923), NYM (1934), NCNC (1944), and militancy of trade unions (e.g., Michael Imoudu leading the 1945 General Strike) organized mass resistance.

B. External Factors (International Scene):

- **Impact of World War II (1939–1945):** African soldiers fought alongside European troops, shattering the myth of European supremacy. Returning veterans brought back political awareness and tactical military confidence.
- **The Atlantic Charter (1941):** Signed by Winston Churchill and FDR, Article 3 affirmed the right of all peoples to choose the form of government under which they live—a clause seized upon by West African nationalists.
- **Pan-African Movements & Manchester Congress (1945):** Efforts by Marcus Garvey, W.E.B. Du Bois, and the 1945 Manchester Congress inspired leaders like Azikiwe and Nkrumah to demand immediate liberation.
- **Independence of Asian Nations:** The independence of India and Pakistan in 1947 demonstrated that the British Empire was breakable and negotiable.
- **Influence of UNO & Superpowers:** The creation of the United Nations (1945) and anti-colonial stances of the USA and USSR exerted pressure on European powers to decolonize.

Key Nigerian Nationalists and Their Specific Contributions

Name	Contributions
Herbert Macaulay (1864–1946)	'Father of Nigerian Nationalism': Founded the Nigerian National Democratic Party (NNDP) in 1923, the first political party in Nigeria. Established the 'Lagos Daily News' and co-founded the National Council of Nigeria and the Cameroons (NCNC) in 1944 alongside Azikiwe.
Nnamdi Azikiwe	

(1904–1996)	'Zik of Africa': Founder of the 'West African Pilot' (1937), which revolutionized militant journalism. Became President of NCNC in 1946, mobilized youth movements (Zikist Movement), and became Nigeria's first Governor-General and President.
Obafemi Awolowo (1909–1987)	Founder of the Egbe Omo Oduduwa and leader of the Action Group (AG) in 1951. Introduced free primary education and welfare reforms in the Western Region, serving as a chief advocate for structural federalism
Ahmadu Bello (1910–1966)	Sardauna of Sokoto: Leader of the Northern People's Congress (NPC) and Premier of the Northern Region. Played a vital role in unifying the North and protecting its political interests during constitutional negotiations.
Anthony Enahoro (1923–2010)	Member of the Action Group who moved the historic motion for Nigeria's self-government in 1953, setting a definitive timeline for independence.
Ernest Ikoli	A journalist and co-founder of the Nigerian Youth Movement.
H.O. Davies	Member of the Nigerian Youth Movement; educated in London and played an active role in anti-colonial struggles.

EFFECTS OF NATIONALISM IN NIGERIA

1. Constitutional Developments

The nationalist struggle in Nigeria directly influenced the evolution of the country's constitutional framework. Pressure from nationalists demanding more inclusive governance and political representation compelled the British colonial administration to introduce progressive constitutional reforms. These began with the Clifford Constitution of 1922, which allowed limited elective representation, followed by the Richards Constitution of 1946, which attempted to promote regional representation. The Macpherson Constitution of 1951 further deepened regional autonomy and allowed more Nigerians to participate in governance. Ultimately, the Lyttleton Constitution of 1954 laid the groundwork for a federal structure, setting the stage for self-rule and independence.

2. Emergence of Political Parties

As political consciousness grew, Nigerians began to form organised political parties to articulate nationalist interests and push for independence. Early parties such as the Nigerian National Democratic Party (NNDP) and later the National Council of Nigeria and the Cameroons (NCNC), Action Group (AG), and Northern People's Congress (NPC) became powerful tools for mobilisation. These parties not only contested elections but also served as platforms for articulating grievances, proposing reforms, and engaging the colonial government in political dialogue. They helped to coordinate nationalist activities across regions, despite differing ideologies and ethnic leanings.

3. Political Awareness and Mass Participation

Nationalist campaigns significantly heightened political awareness among Nigerians. Public rallies, newspapers, educational campaigns, and protests helped inform the masses about their rights and the need for self-governance. The once passive population became actively involved in the political process, with students, market women, artisans, and professionals joining the struggle. This mass participation fostered a sense of national identity and prepared Nigerians to take up leadership roles in a post-independence era.

4. Formation of Trade Unions and Interest Groups

The nationalist era witnessed the rapid rise of trade unions and pressure groups that played a strategic role in challenging colonial authority. Organisations like the Nigeria Union of Teachers (NUT), Railway Workers Union, and Nigerian Trade Union Congress (NTUC) became vocal advocates for both workers' welfare and political liberation. These bodies coordinated strikes, issued demands for better conditions, and supported nationalist leaders. They became key stakeholders in the political landscape, reinforcing the legitimacy of nationalist aspirations.

5. Independence and Sovereignty

One of the most profound effects of nationalism in Nigeria was the eventual attainment of independence. Years of agitation, negotiation, and political struggle culminated in the declaration of Nigeria as a sovereign state on 1st October 1960. This landmark event

marked the end of British colonial rule and the beginning of self-governance, with Nigerians taking control of their political institutions. The achievement of independence remains the most visible outcome of the nationalist movement and a testament to the collective efforts of Nigerian patriots.

6. Ethnic and Regional Politics

Despite the unifying goals of early nationalism, the movement later gave rise to regional and ethnic divisions. Political parties that emerged were often based along ethnic or regional lines — for instance, NCNC in the East, AG in the West, and NPC in the North. These divisions fuelled competition for political dominance and undermined national unity. The result was the entrenchment of ethnic consciousness, which later contributed to political instability, mutual suspicion among regions, and ultimately the Nigerian Civil War

Assignment:

1. *“Examine the role of the press in the development of nationalism in Nigeria.”*

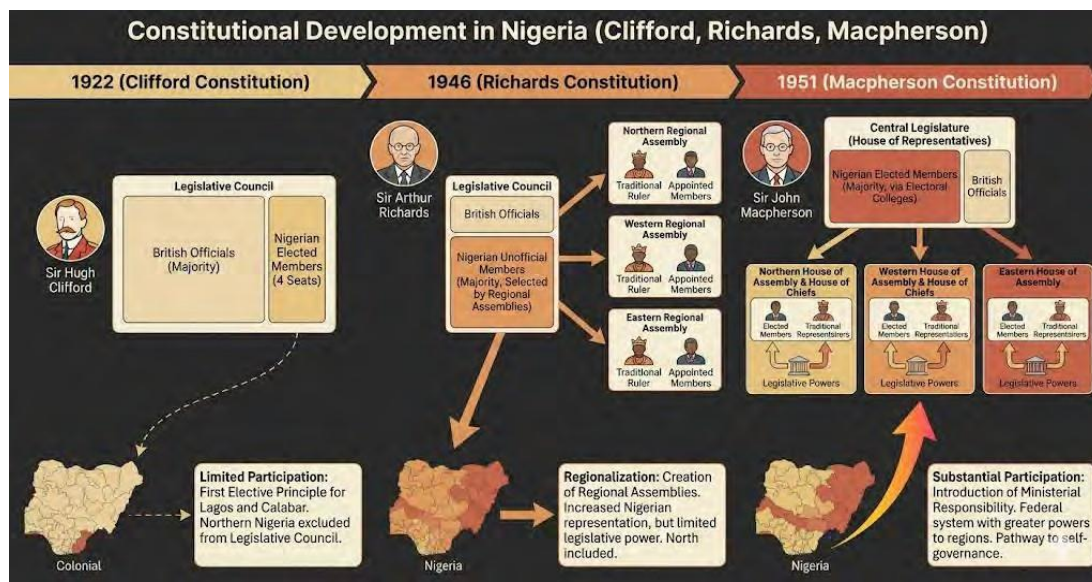
Week: Three

Topic: Constitutional Development in Nigeria 1

Clifford's Constitution

A constitution is a body of fundamental principles, rules, and regulations that govern the political organization, powers, and operations of a state. It defines the rights and duties of citizens and the structure and powers of the organs of government.

Constitutional development in Nigeria refers to the progressive changes in the legal and political frameworks established by colonial authorities to govern the country, which eventually led to self-government and independence. These constitutions laid the foundation for representative governance, federalism, and democratic participation.



. The Clifford Constitution (1922)

Following protests from the National Congress of British West Africa (NCBWA), Governor Sir Hugh Clifford introduced the 1922 Constitution to replace the 1914 Nigerian Council set up by Lord Lugard.

Main Features:

- **Introduction of the Elective Principle:** For the first time in British West Africa, the principle of election was introduced, allowing four elected African representatives (3 for Lagos, 1 for Calabar).

- **Establishment of the Legislative Council:** Consisted of 46 members (27 official/British members and 19 unofficial members, of which only 4 were elected).
- **Exclusion of Northern Nigeria:** The Legislative Council's authority was restricted to the Southern Colony and Protectorate. Northern Nigeria was governed directly by Proclamations issued by the Governor.

Executive Council Supremacy: An Executive Council composed exclusively of British officials advised the Governor, who held total veto power over legislation. Merits:

- It introduced representative/elective government to Nigeria for the first time.
- It stimulated the growth of political parties and party politics, beginning with the NNDP.
- It gave educated Nigerians their first taste of participation in law-making.

Demerits:

- The Northern Provinces were completely excluded from the Legislative Council, so it did not cover the whole country.
- The franchise was highly restricted, limited to a tiny wealthy and literate elite in Lagos and Calabar.
- Official members were in the majority, so real power remained firmly with the Governor and the colonial government.
- It did not provide for regional or federal structures suited to Nigeria's diversity.

The Richards Constitution, 1946

Introduced by Governor Sir Arthur Richards, this constitution took effect in 1947 and was significant for introducing regionalism into Nigerian constitutional development.

Features:

- It unified Nigeria under one Legislative Council for the first time, bringing the Northern Provinces into the central legislature.
- It divided Nigeria into three regions – Northern, Western and Eastern – each with its own Regional House of Assembly (and the North additionally had a House of Chiefs).
- It provided for a central Legislative Council with a majority of unofficial (Nigerian) members for the first time, although official members still dominated the Executive Council.

- Regional Houses of Assembly had only deliberative/advisory powers and could only discuss matters before they went to the central Legislative Council; they had no real legislative power of their own.
- Members of the Regional Houses were mostly selected through indirect elections via Native Authorities rather than by direct popular vote.

Merits:

- It was the first constitution to give recognition to Nigeria's regional/ethnic diversity by creating three regions, laying the foundation for federalism.
- It brought the North into the mainstream of national political life for the first time.
- It increased the number and proportion of unofficial (Nigerian) members in the central legislature.
- It encouraged the growth of nationalist political activity and the formation of broader political associations such as the NCNC.

Demerits:

- Regional Houses had no real legislative powers – merely advisory/deliberative, which frustrated regional aspirations.
- Members were largely selected rather than directly elected, so it did not fully reflect popular will.
- The Governor and Executive Council still retained overriding powers over the Legislative Council.
- Nigerian nationalists, especially Herbert Macaulay and Nnamdi Azikiwe, criticised it strongly for being imposed without adequate consultation with Nigerians.

The Macpherson Constitution, 1951

Introduced by Governor Sir John Macpherson, this constitution resulted from wider consultation with Nigerians than the earlier ones and represented a significant step towards self-government.

Features:

- It provided for a central House of Representatives with an unofficial (Nigerian) majority, along with three Regional Houses of Assembly (and a House of Chiefs in the North and West).

- It introduced a form of “semi-federalism” by giving the Regional Houses real legislative powers over specified regional matters for the first time.
- Members of the Regional Houses of Assembly were now elected (though still by indirect election in most cases) and in turn elected representatives to the central House of Representatives.
- It provided for Nigerian ministers, who were appointed from among elected members to head certain government departments, giving Nigerians their first real taste of executive responsibility.
- It was based on extensive consultations with Nigerians at village, divisional, provincial and regional levels before being drafted – hence it is often described as the first truly “Nigerian” constitution.

Merits:

- It was the product of genuine consultation with Nigerians at all levels, unlike earlier constitutions.
- It gave real legislative powers to the Regional Houses of Assembly for the first time.
- It introduced Nigerian ministers into the Executive Council, giving Nigerians practical experience in the running of government departments.
- It further strengthened the federal structure of Nigeria by clearly defining regional and central legislative responsibilities.
- It stimulated even greater political party activity across the country.

Demerits:

- The system of indirect elections in many areas still did not reflect the direct will of the electorate.
- It created friction and rivalry between the regions and the centre over the sharing of powers, exposing the difficulty of harmonising unity with diversity.
- The position of the Governor and the reserve powers of the centre still limited genuine self-government.

- Disagreements over the constitution eventually led to its breakdown and the need for the 1953 London and Lagos Constitutional Conferences that produced the Lyttleton Constitution.

Comparative Summary of the Three Constitutions

Constitution	Year	Key Feature
Clifford Constitution	1922	First elective principle; Legislative Council excluded the North
Richards Constitution	1946	Introduced regionalism – three regions with advisory Houses of Assembly
Macpherson Constitution	1951	Gave real legislative powers to regions; introduced Nigerian ministers; based on wide consultation

Assignment: Draw a comparative table showing the features of the Clifford, Richards and Macpherson Constitutions.

Week: Four

Topic: Constitutional Development in Nigeria II

Background to the Lyttleton Constitution

The Macpherson Constitution of 1951 broke down as a result of disagreements among the major political parties and regions over the sharing of powers between the centre and the regions, especially following the 1953 crisis in the House of Representatives (the motion for self-government in 1953 moved by Anthony Enahoro, and the subsequent walkout by the Northern delegation). This crisis led to the London Constitutional Conference of 1953 and the Lagos Constitutional Conference of 1954, out of which the new constitution – named after the Secretary of State for the Colonies, Oliver Lyttleton – emerged. It came into force in 1954.

Features of the Lyttleton Constitution, 1954

- It formally established a truly federal system of government in Nigeria for the first time, with clearly defined Federal, Regional and Concurrent Legislative Lists specifying the powers of the centre and the regions.
- Nigeria was divided into a Federation of three Regions – Northern, Western and Eastern – plus the Federal Territory of Lagos, which served as the federal capital.
- Each Region was given its own Regional Legislature, Regional Executive Council (headed by a Premier) and Regional Public Service, with substantial self-government in regional matters.
- A Federal (Central) Government was established, comprising a Council of Ministers and a Federal House of Representatives, with responsibility for matters on the Federal and Concurrent Legislative Lists (e.g. defence, external affairs, currency).
- Regional Governors and a Governor-General were retained to represent the British Crown, but Nigerian ministers now controlled most departments both at the centre and in the regions.
- Members of the House of Representatives and the Regional Houses of Assembly were elected directly, with an expanded franchise, marking increased popular participation compared to earlier constitutions.
- The Public Service was regionalised, with separate Regional Public Service Commissions, giving each region control over its own civil service.
- The Southern Cameroons was granted quasi-regional status within the Federation.

The Federal Structure Introduced

The Lyttleton Constitution introduced a genuine federal structure comprising two tiers of government – the Federal Government at the centre and three Regional Governments (Northern, Western and Eastern) – each with its own legislature, executive and defined powers. This marked a fundamental departure from the unitary and quasi-federal arrangements of the earlier constitutions and reflected Nigeria's ethnic, cultural and geographical diversity. The distribution of powers was captured in three lists:

- Exclusive Legislative List: matters over which only the Federal Government could legislate (e.g. defence, external affairs, currency, immigration).
- Concurrent Legislative List: matters over which both the Federal and Regional Governments could legislate, with federal law prevailing in case of conflict.
- Residual matters: powers not listed as federal or concurrent were left to the Regions to legislate upon.

Significance of the Lyttleton Constitution

- It laid the true foundation for federalism in Nigeria, a structure that (with modifications) has persisted to the present day.
- It gave the Regions substantial self-government, allowing each region to develop at its own pace according to its peculiar needs and priorities.
- It expanded the franchise and increased direct popular participation in elections, deepening representative government.
- It paved the way for the regions to attain self-government at different times: the Western and Eastern Regions became self-governing in 1957, and the Northern Region in 1959, ahead of full national independence in 1960.
- It strengthened political parties along regional lines (NPC in the North, AG in the West, NCNC in the East), which shaped the pattern of Nigerian party politics for years to come.
- It served as a direct stepping stone to the Independence Constitution of 1960.

Weaknesses of the Lyttleton Constitution

- By strengthening regionalism, it also deepened ethnic and regional loyalties at the expense of national unity, entrenching the North-West-East tripartite political divide.
- The unequal sizes of the regions (the North being far larger than the West and East combined) created an imbalance that would later generate serious political tensions.
- Minority ethnic groups within each region expressed fears of domination by the majority ethnic group in their region, leading to demands for the creation of more states/regions (addressed later by the Willink Commission of 1957).
- The Southern Cameroons' quasi-regional status raised questions about its eventual status that were not fully resolved until the 1961 plebiscite.

Assignment: Explain, in about half a page, how the Lyttleton Constitution of 1954 laid the foundation for federalism in Nigeria, and state the dates on which each region attained self-government.

Week: Five

Topic: Constitutional Development in Nigeria II

The Independence Constitution, 1960

Following further constitutional conferences held in London in 1957 and 1958, and after the three Regions had attained self-government, Nigeria was granted full political independence from Britain on 1st October, 1960. The Independence Constitution came into effect on this date.

Features:

1. Nigeria became an independent sovereign state within the British Commonwealth, but remained a monarchy (a Dominion), with Queen Elizabeth II as the ceremonial Head of State, represented locally by a Governor-General.
2. It retained and consolidated the federal structure established under the Lyttleton Constitution – a Federal Government and three Regional Governments (Northern, Western, Eastern), each with its own Legislature, Executive Council (headed by a Premier) and Public Service.
3. A bicameral Federal Legislature was established, comprising a Senate (Upper House) and a House of Representatives (Lower House).
4. Executive power at the centre was exercised by a Prime Minister and Council of Ministers responsible to the Federal Parliament, following the British parliamentary/cabinet system of government.
5. A Bill of Rights (fundamental human rights provisions) was entrenched in the constitution for the first time, guaranteeing rights such as the right to life, personal liberty, fair hearing, freedom of expression, and freedom from discrimination.
6. An independent judiciary was established, headed by the Federal Supreme Court, with appeals still possible to the Privy Council in London.
7. Tafawa Balewa (NPC) became Nigeria's first Prime Minister, while the ceremonial framework was still monarchical, so at independence a Governor-General represented the Queen.

Merits:

1. It granted Nigeria full political independence and international sovereignty.

2. It entrenched a Bill of Rights that protected the fundamental rights of citizens for the first time.
3. It consolidated the federal system, giving the regions substantial autonomy.
4. It provided a democratic, elected government based on popular participation.

Demerits:

1. Nigeria remained a monarchy, still owing allegiance to the British Crown, which many nationalists felt was inconsistent with true independence.
2. The Governor-General, though a ceremonial figure, was still seen by some as a symbol of continued British influence.
3. Appeals could still be made to the Privy Council in London, meaning the highest judicial authority was still external to Nigeria.
4. Regional imbalance (the North being larger than the West and East combined) remained unresolved and continued to generate political tension.

The Republican Constitution, 1963

On 1st October, 1963, exactly three years after independence, Nigeria became a Republic, and the Republican Constitution came into force, completing the process of full constitutional autonomy from Britain.

Features:

1. Nigeria ceased to be a monarchy under the British Crown and became a Republic, with an executive President as Head of State replacing the Queen and the Governor-General.
2. Nnamdi Azikiwe became Nigeria's first (largely ceremonial) President, while Tafawa Balewa continued as Prime Minister, so the parliamentary system of government (with a Prime Minister as Head of Government) was retained even though the country was now a Republic.
3. The Federal Supreme Court was renamed the Supreme Court of Nigeria and became the final court of appeal, ending appeals to the Privy Council in London.
4. The federal structure of the Federation and three Regions, the bicameral legislature, and the Bill of Rights from the 1960 Constitution were all retained.
5. A new Region – the Mid-Western Region – was created out of the former Western Region in 1963, making Nigeria a Federation of four Regions.

Merits:

6. It completed Nigeria's full sovereignty and total break from British constitutional monarchy.
7. It made the Supreme Court of Nigeria the final court of appeal, symbolising full judicial independence.
8. The creation of the Mid-West Region addressed, to some extent, the fears of minority ethnic groups in the former Western Region regarding domination.
9. It boosted national pride and the sense of full self-determination.

Demerits:

10. It did not resolve the underlying problem of regional imbalance, since the North remained far larger and more populous than the other three regions combined.
11. Ethnic and regional rivalries, minority agitation and mutual suspicion among the regions persisted and even intensified.
12. The parliamentary system, combined with strong regionalism, contributed to serious political crises (e.g. the 1962/63 census crisis and the Western Region crisis of 1962), which eventually undermined the stability of the First Republic and paved the way for the military coup of January 1966.

Comparative Analysis of the Constitutions (1922–1963)

Constitution	Year	Major Contribution
Clifford Constitution	1922	Introduced the elective principle; excluded the North
Richards Constitution	1946	Introduced regionalism – three regions with advisory powers
Macpherson Constitution	1951	Gave regions real legislative powers; introduced Nigerian ministers
Lyttleton Constitution	1954	Established true federalism; defined Federal/Regional/Concurrent powers

Constitution	Year	Major Contribution
Independence Constitution	1960	Granted full political independence; entrenched a Bill of Rights
Republican Constitution	1963	Made Nigeria a Republic; ended appeals to the Privy Council; created the Mid-West Region

Overall, the constitutional development of Nigeria from 1922 to 1963 shows a clear, gradual and progressive movement: from an exclusively British-controlled Legislative Council, through increasing regional autonomy and Nigerian participation, to full political independence and, ultimately, complete republican status. Each constitution built upon the achievements and addressed some of the weaknesses of the one before it, although the fundamental problem of balancing regional/ethnic diversity with national unity remained largely unresolved throughout the period.

Assignment:

1. Explain, in about half a page, why Nigeria's becoming a Republic in 1963 is considered the completion of the country's constitutional independence from Britain.

Week: Six

Topic: Military Rule in Nigeria:

Meaning of Military Rule and Coup d'État

Military rule is a system of government in which the armed forces of a country seize political power, usually by force, and administer the affairs of the state, suspending or replacing the existing civilian constitutional order. A coup d'état (French for “blow of state”) is the sudden, illegal and often violent overthrow of an existing government, usually by the military. Nigeria experienced its first coup on 15th January, 1966, which ended the First Republic and ushered in over a decade of military rule (with intervals of civilian rule).

Reasons for Military Intervention in Nigeria

1. Political instability and crises of the First Republic, including the disputed 1962/63 population census, the Western Region crisis of 1962 and the widely disputed and violence-marred 1964/65 federal and regional elections.
2. Widespread corruption among civilian politicians, who were perceived as using public office for personal enrichment.
3. Intense ethnic and regional rivalry among the major political parties (NPC, AG, NCNC), which threatened national unity.
4. Breakdown of law and order, particularly the widespread violence, arson and killings that followed the 1965 Western Region elections (“Wetie” crisis).
5. Nepotism, favouritism and abuse of power by the ruling political class, which alienated large sections of the population.
6. The desire of some military officers to “save the nation” from what they perceived as failed and corrupt civilian leadership, as claimed in the justification for the 15th January 1966 coup.
7. Weak and ineffective civilian institutions that could not resolve the political deadlock through constitutional means.

Achievements of Military Rule in Nigeria

1. **Infrastructural Development:** several military administrations embarked on major infrastructural projects, including roads, bridges, airports, dams, and universities, often more speedily than civilian bureaucratic processes allowed.
2. **Centralisation and National Unity:** military rule, being hierarchical and command-based, helped hold Nigeria together as one country during and after the civil war (1967–1970), preventing the disintegration of the federation.
3. **State/Local Government Creation:** the military created additional states and local government areas (e.g. from 4 regions to 12 states in 1967, and subsequently up to 36 states), which brought government closer to the people and addressed some minority agitations.
4. **Civil Service Reforms:** reforms such as the Udoji Commission of 1974 improved salary structures and reorganised the public service.
5. **Economic Policies:** some regimes introduced significant economic policies such as the Indigenisation Decree (1972/1977), aimed at increasing indigenous ownership and control of the economy.
6. Some regimes initiated genuine and relatively speedy transition programmes that returned Nigeria to civilian rule (e.g. the Second Republic in 1979).

Discipline and orderliness were, in certain periods, enforced in public institutions through programmes such as the War Against Indiscipline (WAI) of 1984–1985

Failures of Military Rule in Nigeria

1. **Dictatorship and Authoritarianism:** military regimes ruled by decrees/edicts, without accountability to any elected legislature, suspending the constitution and fundamental human rights.
2. **Suppression of Political Freedom:** political parties, free press and civil liberties were often banned or severely restricted, and dissent was frequently met with repression.
3. **Corruption:** contrary to their claims of fighting corruption, many military regimes were themselves associated with massive corruption, embezzlement and mismanagement of public funds.
4. **Human Rights Abuses:** several regimes were responsible for extra-judicial killings, unlawful detention without trial, and suppression of the press.

5. Political Instability: the frequency of coups and counter-coups (1966, 1975, 1976, 1983, 1985, 1993) created chronic instability and discontinuity in government policies.
6. Militarisation of Society: prolonged military rule bred a culture of command and force rather than dialogue and consensus-building in Nigerian political life.
7. Delayed Democratic Development: military rule repeatedly interrupted and delayed Nigeria's democratic and constitutional development, denying successive generations the experience of sustained civilian governance.
8. The annulment of the 12th June, 1993 presidential election (widely regarded as Nigeria's freest and fairest election) by the military government plunged the country into a severe political crisis.

Summary Timeline of Major Military Regimes

Head of State	Period
Major-General J.T.U. Aguiyi-Ironsi	January – July 1966
General Yakubu Gowon	1966 – 1975
General Murtala Mohammed	1975 – 1976
General Olusegun Obasanjo	1976 – 1979
Major-General Muhammadu Buhari	1983 – 1985
General Ibrahim Babangida	1985 – 1993
General Sani Abacha	1993 – 1998
General Abdulsalami Abubakar	1998 – 1999

Assignment: Write short notes on the causes and consequences of the annulment of the 12th June, 1993 presidential election in Nigeria.